

ETHIOPIA Food Security Outlook

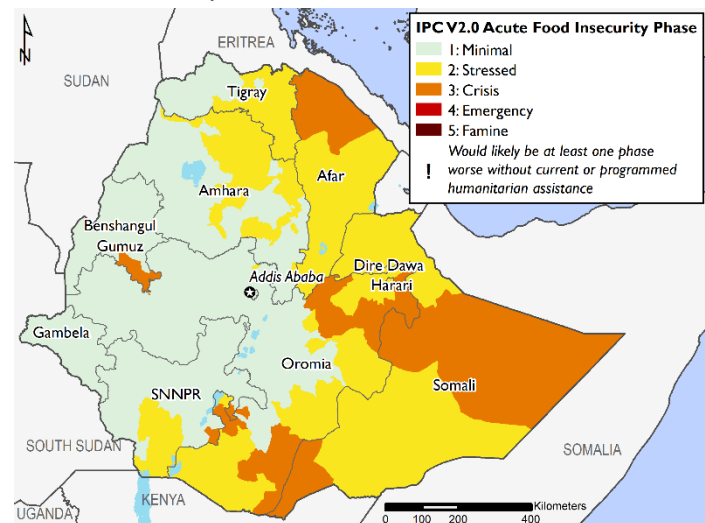
October 2018 to May 2019

As pastoral and some agricultural areas cope with poor rainfall, conflict also drives needs in other areas

KEY MESSAGES

- Southeastern pastoral areas continue to recover from drought in 2016 and 2017, while northern pastoral Afar experienced poor rainfall throughout 2018. These areas will remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) through at least May 2019. Localized areas that saw poor 2018 *Belg* and/or *Kiremt* seasonal performance will also experience Stressed (IPC Phase 2) and Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes. Additionally, conflict-affected woredas, particularly those that have seen associated levels of displacement, will also likely remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3).
- June to September *Kiremt* seasonal rainfall was generally good throughout most of the country, and national *Meher* production is expected to be near average. Over parts of eastern Oromia, southern Tigray, eastern Amhara, and northern SNNPR, however, rainfall was below-average, leading to reduced production prospects. July to September *Karan/Karma* rains were also below-average in northern pastoral Afar. Although October to December 2018 *Deyr* seasonal accumulation in southern pastoral areas is forecast to be near average, to date in October, rainfall is below average.
- While the country continues to respond to the needs of drought affected populations, large populations are also displaced by conflict throughout the country. Areas where intercommunal clashes are having the most significant impact on food security outcomes include parts of Oromia, SNNPR, Somali, and Benishangul Gumuz regions.

Current food security outcomes, October 2018



Source: FEWS NET

FEWS NET classification is IPC-compatible. IPC-compatible analysis follows key IPC protocols but does not necessarily reflect the consensus of national food security partners.

NATIONAL OVERVIEW

Current Situation

The rainfall situation throughout much of the country remains generally favorable. The *Kiremt* (June to September) rains started early (by up to 20 days) over much of western, central and northern areas of the country. In these areas the rainfall accumulation was average to above average and the distribution was generally normal. This continued and enhanced seasonal rainfall also resulted in soil moisture over saturation in some areas in late August 2018, leading to flooding in parts of western and central Ethiopia's riverine and low-lying areas, which impacted cropping in affected areas.

However, *Kiremt* rainfall was delayed by up to 20 days over parts of western Oromia, southern Tigray, eastern Amhara, and northern SNNPR. In parts of central and eastern Oromia and neighboring areas of SNNPR the start of season was delayed by

more than 20 days. This, in addition to a two-week dry spell in July/August, contributed to below-average seasonal totals in these areas. In East Hararghe and West Hararghe in particular, rainfall was rather erratic.

Meher harvest prospects are generally good with near normal production expected in most areas. In Amhara and Tigray, harvesting of early maturing crops, such as barley and haricot bean, has already started. In central and western parts of the country, both long and short cycle crops are nearing the harvesting stage. Household income from agricultural labor, agricultural sales, and self-employment is also improving with the new *Meher* harvests.

Areas of the country noted above that experienced poor *Kiremt* seasonal rainfall will see below-average harvests. This is particularly true for parts of East Hararghe and West Hararghe, SNNPR, northeastern Amhara, and southern Tigray. The long dry spell that spanned both the *Belg* and *Kiremt* rains in parts of East Hararghe and West Hararghe impacted long-cycle maize and sorghum crops that were planted during the *Belg* and short-cycle crops like barley and wheat planted during the *Kiremt*. Northern Amhara and southern Tigray will have seen losses in both *Belg* harvests and *Meher* harvests in 2018.

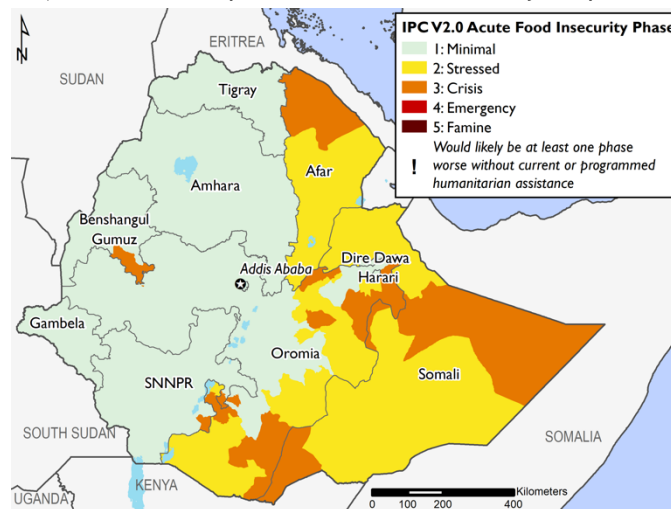
Even in areas that saw good *Kiremt* rainfall performance, however, the continuation of rainfall in October and November in some areas could threaten somewhat *Meher* harvest yields. This unseasonable rainfall, particularly in parts of Tigray, Amhara, SNNPR, and western and central Oromia has the potential to contribute to localized germination in standing crops and/or spoilage of stored harvests for some households.

In northern pastoral and agropastoral areas, the onset of the June to September *Karma/Karan* rains was timely in most areas. Seasonal rainfall totals were also near average, improving water and forage availability for livestock. However, in northern Afar and in Sitti zone the seasonal onset was delayed by one to two weeks. In these areas seasonal rainfall totals were mediocre to well below average and the season was characterized by dust, wind, and thunder storms. In northern Afar, most parts Berhale, Abala and Kuneba woredas saw only seven to ten days of average rainfall in the season. Flooding from the neighboring highlands in Amhara and Tigray did, however, flow into major rangelands in these woredas, contributing to improving vegetative conditions.

In southern pastoral areas, successive improvements in rainfall seasons has improved water and pasture conditions following droughts in 2016 and 2017. Although the March to May *Gu* rainfall ended somewhat early, the onset of the season was timely and cumulative rainfall for the season was above average. *Deyr* rainfall at the beginning of the 2018 season in October, however, has been weak in most areas with two months left in the season.

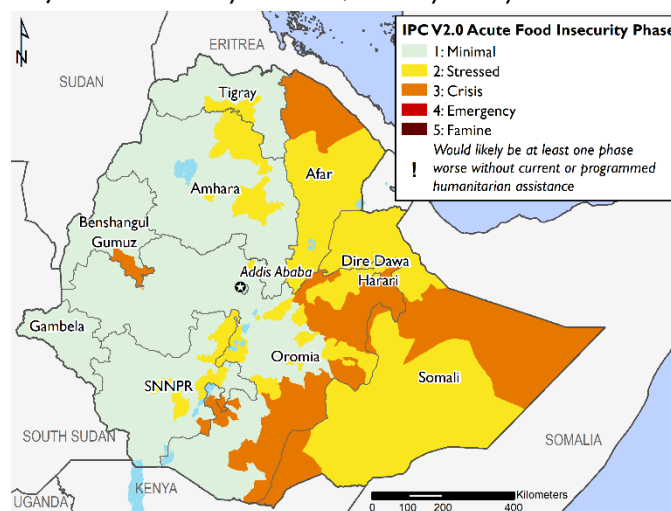
Livestock body conditions and productivity across northern and southern pastoral areas is currently generally average in most areas owing to good seasonal performance. Current water and pasture levels can sustain feed and water needs for livestock in most areas. The good livestock conditions are assisting in maintaining household access to income milk and food from livestock. In northern Afar and parts of Sitti zone, however, water and pasture resources for livestock are limited due to the

Projected food security outcomes, October 2018 to January 2019



Source: FEWS NET

Projected food security outcomes, February to May 2019



Source: FEWS NET

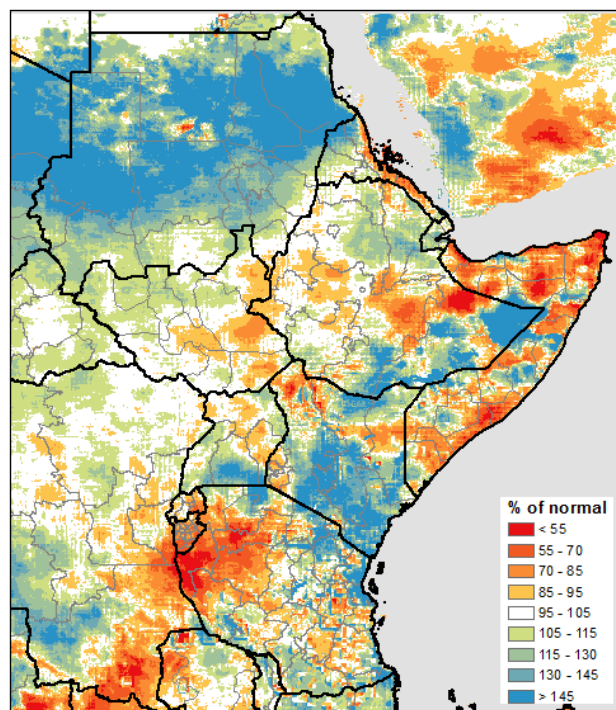
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poor rainfall performance. In southern pastoral areas, while water and pasture conditions are generally good, household herds are still recovering from previous years' droughts.

Staple food prices, particularly for maize, sorghum and wheat, increased in recent months across much of the country. In advance of the *Meher* harvests, demand is seasonally high for staple foods as household stocks run out. Market supply of goods is equally seasonally low in advance of new production supply. Steady depreciation of the Ethiopian Birr and increasing transportation costs are also contributing to the increase in prices.

In August 2018, the Ethiopian Trade and Business Corporation (ETBC), formerly called the Ethiopian Grain Trade Enterprise (EGTE), noted the wholesale price of sorghum and wheat in Addis Ababa was about 50 percent higher than the same time last year and the five-year average. The price of maize in Hossa market increased about 17 percent compared to the same month last year and by about 10 percent compared to the five-year. Likewise, the price of maize in Afder market increased by about 20 percent compared to the same time last year and 40 percent against the five-year. Staple food prices are expected to remain seasonally high across the country through October/November 2018 but then show stability as *Meher* harvest production reaches markets.

Figure 1. CHIRPS-estimated rainfall anomalies, percent of average for June 01 – Sept 30, 2018



Source: USGS/FEWS NET

SEASONAL CALENDAR FOR A TYPICAL YEAR



Source: FEWS NET

Figure 2. Regional breakdown of beneficiaries as of November 8, 2018

Region	Round 1			Round 2			Round 3			Round 4		
	Food	Cash	Total	Food	Cash	Total	Food	Cash	Total	Food	Cash	Total
Amhara	399,021	596,223	995,244	413,966	586,850	1,000,816	909,817	-	909,817	406,043	-	406,043
Somali	1,704,629	-	1,704,629	1,608,964	-	1,608,964	1,470,148	-	1,470,148	284,436	-	284,436
Oromia	1,676,069	1,589,545	3,265,614	2,293,614	892,307	3,185,921	3,196,453	-	3,196,453	1,296,313	-	1,296,313
SNNPR	273,943	487,672	761,615	355,198	311,250	666,448	653,081	-	653,081	149,547	-	149,547
Tigray	337,787	275,487	613,274	309,543	277,274	586,817	576,637	-	576,637	296,227	-	296,227
Afar	442,769	-	442,769	444,592	-	444,592	444,475	-	444,475	295,153	-	295,153
Gambela	44,444	-	44,444	44,444	-	44,444	44,444	-	44,444	18,815	-	18,815
Benishagul	13,803	-	13,803	13,803	-	13,803	13,812	-	13,812	11,962	-	11,962
Harari	15,783	-	15,783	15,742	-	15,742	15,742	-	15,742	15,783	-	15,783
Dire Dawa	26,480	-	26,480	37,649	-	37,649	39,450	-	39,450	38,360	-	38,360
	4,934,728	2,948,927	7,883,655	5,537,514	2,067,681	7,605,195	7,364,058	-	7,364,058	2,812,639	-	2,812,639

Source: NDRMC Food Aid Prioritization Committee

At the same time, and following increasing demand for holiday festivities and improved livestock body conditions, livestock sale prices across most markets in pastoral regions have seen good improvements. For example, the price for an average size goat in September 2018 in Abala, Jijiga and Shinile markets increased by 86, 30 and 30 percent respectively compared to the four-year average and 18, 44 and 8 percent respectively compared to the same time last year. Moreover, in Gode market in Somali region, the price for an average size goat increased by about 50 percent compared to the same month last year and the five-year average. Despite the increase in cereal prices, livestock-to-cereal terms of trade are generally stable. In the Somali region, however, many poor households lost a significant portion of their herds due to drought in 2016 and 2017 and have fewer saleable animals.

Since late 2017 intermittent clashes among different ethnic groups across different parts of the country have continued. According to the 12th round IOM Displacement Tracking Matrix, in 2018 alone, more than 294,677, 738,661, and 315,516 individuals were displaced in Oromia, SNNPR, and Somali regions, respectively. In addition to this, according to NDRMC media briefing, about 95,000 people in Benishangul Gumuz region were displaced due to ethnic clashes. Since May 2018, Benishangul Gumuz region, which has been considered relatively stable in past years, has seen several ethnic clashes including one in June in the regional capital Assosa in which more than 10 people were killed. Moreover, in late September 2018, an ethnic clash in Kamashi zone of Benishangul Gumuz region resulted in 20 deaths and displaced more than 95,000 people respectively. The clashes occurred after two officials of the Benishangul Gumuz regional state were killed by unidentified gunmen.

Localized conflict between communities in Gedeo zone of SNNPR and West Guji zone of Oromia region led to the rapid displacement of close to one million people between April and July 2018. Since mid-August 2018, there have been efforts by the government to return displaced people to their areas of origin after successive government and community leader-led peace and reconciliation conferences. However, OCHA's Gedeo-West Guji Displacement Crisis report from October 9th indicates that some IDPs that had returned to their area of origin have started to go back to Gedeo due to insecurity.

In general, conflict among communities in Oromia, SNNPR, Somali and Benishangul Gumuz regions has affected households' access to agriculture and pastoral livelihoods either through direct threat of violence or as households face limited opportunities when they become displaced. Host communities have also been somewhat impacted as the presence of large displaced populations often coincides with increased competition for land resources and on food and labor markets. A July 2018 ENCU assessment report found that out of 2,367 'walk-in' screened children among Gedeo IDPs in Dila site, 174 children were found to be severely acutely malnourished. In the same site out of 714 screened pregnant and lactating mothers (PLW), 171 had a low MUAC. On the other hand, in Gedeb woreda IDP site where IDPs exceed the host community in size (326,000 IDPs and roughly 290,000 residents), out of a total of 18,400 malnutrition children screened 444 were found to be severely acutely malnourished. In the same site, out of 11,823 PLM screened 6,803 had a low MUAC.

According to UNCHR, as of August 2018, the total registered number of refugees and asylum seekers in Ethiopia was 905,831. The country of origin breakdown as a percentage is 46.6 from South Sudan, 28.4 from Somalia, 19.2 from Eritrea, 4.9 from Sudan, and less than one percent from other countries. Between January to August 2018, approximately 36,185 refugees arrived in Ethiopia, including 1,626 in August 2018. The reopening of the border crossing points between Eritrea and Ethiopia resulted in an increase in the number of new arrivals from Eritrea by 9,905 per a UNCHR report released on October 13, 2018.

According to the Emergency Nutrition Coordination Unit (ENCU) of the NDRMC for the period of June to July 2018, admissions to therapeutic feeding programs (TFP) across Ethiopia dropped by four percent from 30,390 to 29,285 children under the age of five. June 2018 had the highest number of admissions of any month between January and July 2018. However, TFP admissions in Oromia, SNNPR, Afar, and Gambela rose by 11.2, 10.7, 5 and 37 percent respectively in July 2018 compared to June 2018 figures. TFP admissions showed a decline in July 2018 in Somali region by 20 percent, in Tigray by nine percent, and in Amhara by six percent. The significant drop in admissions in Somali region could be due, at least in part, to the low reporting rate (well below the acceptable reporting rate cutoff of 80%). For example, the reporting rate in Afeder zone was 38 percent in July 2018.

The 2018 Humanitarian Disaster Response Plan document (HDRP), updated in October, identified 7.95 million people to be targeted with emergency from October 2018, an increase from March due to the significant spike in conflict related internal displacements. After the release of the HDRP document in March 2018, three rounds of food distributions were launched by the NDRMC-led Prioritization Committee. The number of planned and addressed beneficiaries vary across each round of distribution. Figure 2 shows the estimated number of beneficiaries served from the past three rounds of distributions. In past years at this time of the year, operators were implementing the 6th or 7th round of distributions, although this year operators did implement the bridging rounds prior to the start of the 2018 HDRP response. However, this year, operators were only able to recently start the dispatch of the fourth round of food allocation in September/October. Shortfalls in funding the response are largely for woredas targeted with cash-based transfers. In many regions this year, food dispatches and distributions have been done every other month, but the transfer or ration size for each distribution remains the same. Moreover, in Somali region, due to security related issues, WFP did not distribute emergency food assistance in Dawa zone in 2018 and the status of beneficiaries is not known.

A food security crisis continues in many southern pastoral areas and in conflict affected areas of SNNPR, the Oromia- Somali border, and Kamashi zone of Benishangul Gumuz. In southern pastoral areas, although pasture and water conditions have very significantly improved, household purchasing power is still restricted by herd losses in 2016 and 2017 that have not recovered. Populations of greatest concern in conflict-affected areas are displaced populations and those who face restricted access to their agricultural and pastoral livelihoods due to insecurity. Poor households in northern Afar are also facing difficulty meeting their food needs due largely to poor rainfall in 2018. Livestock body conditions and productivity are down due to the limited availability of pasture and water resources. In East Hararghe and West Hararghe, successive mediocre seasons for an area with a high population density, very low land holdings, and sporadic conflict with Somali region has resulted in consecutively mediocre harvests and declines in household incomes. In October, many poor households are facing difficulty meeting food needs.

Assumptions

The most-likely scenario for October 2018 to May 2019 is based on the following national-level assumptions:

- Although rainfall in October has been below average, forecasts call for October to December *Deyr/Hageya* 2018 rainfall totals to be average to slightly below average. The poor start to the season could adversely affect crop production and water and pasture availability, however.
- *Gu/Genna* (March to May 2018) cumulative rainfall is likely to be average. However, below-average rainfall is likely in localized areas of southern Somali region.
- Cumulative rainfall during the *Belg* season (February to May 2019) is likely to be average to above average in central areas and average in southwestern and northern *Belg* season-benefiting areas of the country.
- Cumulative rainfall during the *Diraac/Sugum* season (March to May 2019) in northern pastoral areas is likely to be average to above average.
- In southeastern pastoral areas, pasture and water availability is expected to seasonally improve following the *Deyr* rainfall through December 2018, and then likely to typically deteriorate through the dry season through February 2019. Following the 2019 *Gu* rainy season, regeneration of pasture and water is expected to be average. While the rains are expected to lead to improved livestock body conditions and productivity, especially as camels and goats conceive and

give birth during the *Deyr* season, due to the high level of livestock deaths in 2016/17, particularly in parts of Somali region, cumulative livestock productivity, including for milk, will remain below average.

- In central and southern pastoral areas of Afar and northern Somali (Sitti and Fafan zones) regions, availability of pasture and water is expected to seasonably deteriorate during the dry season through March 2019, but some areas in the northwest that received below-average *Karan/Karma* (June to September 2018) rains are likely to more rapidly deteriorate. With the 2019 *Sugum* rainy season, regeneration is expected to return to near-normal levels, which is likely to lead to improved livestock body conditions, conception rates, births, and seasonal livestock productivity.
- Livestock prices are likely to follow normal seasonal trends throughout the country during the outlook period and remain above average.
- Prices for locally-produced staple foods, such as maize, wheat, and sorghum, are expected to seasonally decline, beginning in November/December 2018 through January 2019, due to increases in market supply from the *Meher* harvests. From February/March 2019 onwards, staple food prices are expected to gradually rise and follow a normal, seasonal pattern.
- The Ethiopian Birr is expected to continue to gradually depreciate through the outlook period due to tight foreign reserves, global strengthening of the USD, and increasing interest due on USD-denominated debt. As a result, this is likely to translate into higher domestic fuel and transportation costs.
- National 2018/19 *Meher* production is likely to be average. However, production is expected to be below average in localized areas of northeastern Amhara, southern Tigray, eastern and central Oromia, following erratic and below-normal *Kiremt* rainfall.
- From October 2018 to January 2019, agricultural labor opportunities are likely to be normal, following typical labor demand for harvesting with the anticipated near-average, national *Meher* production, with some regional area variability. Similarly, in *Belg*-growing areas, with expected average February to May 2019 seasonal rainfall, agricultural labor is likely to remain normal.
- With the anticipated average *Deyr/Hageya* rains, the availability of casual local labor and self-employment opportunities is expected to increase from October 2018 to January 2019 in southern pastoral areas and then again during the *Gu/Genna* rains from March to May 2019.
- Generally countrywide, social support, both in-kind and cash, is expected to slightly increase from October 2018 to January 2019, with a likely average *Meher* harvest and higher income from livestock sales and products.
- The number of cases of Acute Watery Diarrhea (AWD) is expected to increase during the dry season as pilgrims travel to holy water sites during this season, (November 2018 to February 2019) particularly in holy water sites of Amhara and Tigray regions. In addition, during the *Deyr/Hageya* rains from October to December, pastoral communities, who are dependent on open water sources for their consumption and sanitation, particularly in Somali and southern Oromia regions, are more susceptible to be infected by AWD. An increase in AWD outbreaks is also possible in state-run cotton farm areas of Afar region during October 2018 to January 2019 due to the concentration of daily laborers, who are harvesting without the proper sanitation facilities and access to potable water.
- The national level of acute malnutrition across seasons is Alert (GAM prevalence of 5 to 9.9 percent), but there are regional differences, with higher wasting levels (Serious, 10 to 14.9 percent, to Critical, 15 to 29.9 percent) prevalent in several zones in Somali, Oromia, Amhara, and Afar regions. The general national level of acute malnutrition is expected to improve from October 2018 to January 2019, when there is increased food access across the country following the *Meher* harvest. Between February and May 2019, as food access typically decreases, the level of wasting is expected to increase. Despite these seasonal changes in food access, which influences wasting levels, overall acute malnutrition at the national level is likely to remain within typical Alert levels during the outlook period. However, clear differences in severity of malnutrition are expected in Somali region, where typical Critical wasting levels are expected throughout the scenario period, which is attributable to food insecurity and the high disease burden. In addition, in Afar, Oromia, and Amhara regions typical Alert wasting levels are likely between October 2018 to January 2019 but deterioration in acute

malnutrition to typical Serious levels from February to May 2019 is expected, mainly driven by reduced food access, disease prevalence, and constrained access to health and nutrition services.

- The impact of conflict between Somali and Oromo communities, Gedeo and Guji Oromo, Geri and Borana Oromo, Amhara and Benishangul Gumuz, Tigray and Amhara, and Oromia and Benishangul Gumuz communities are likely to remain a concern throughout the scenario period due to political and regional border tensions and competition for pasture and water resources. This could lead to further displacement, temporarily disrupt humanitarian assistance delivery, restrict movement of people for labor activity, disrupt livelihoods, deteriorate health and nutrition conditions, and hinder trade flows through May 2019.
- The trend of high numbers of Eritrean refugee arrivals is expected to fall following the recent peace agreement between the governments of Ethiopia and Eritrea. With fewer influxes of arrivals, easing pressure on local markets, price stabilization is expected in the host communities of northern Tigray.
- Resource transfers through the Productive Safety Net Program (PSNP) are expected to take place following the typical schedule from January to June 2019.
- Humanitarian assistance is planned and funded only until the first month of 2019 and not through the end of the outlook period for drought affected households; however, based on recent experiences, full delivery is likely to be affected in Somali region and southern and southeastern Oromia due to ongoing conflict. On the other hand, humanitarian assistance for conflict-affected IDPs is planned for parts of Benishangul Gumuz, Somali, Oromia, and SNNP regions, but not funded for the whole of the outlook period. As a result, this assistance is not incorporated into FEWS NET's analysis of projected outcomes.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Food security is expected to remain stable from October 2018 to May 2019 across most of the country owing in part to anticipated near-average October to January *Meher* production and favorable pastoral conditions. Households, particularly in the western and central surplus-producing areas of Oromia, western parts of SNNPR, Amhara, Gambela and Benishangul Gumuz are expected to address their food and non-food needs from their own production and from normal access to income, including local and migratory harvest labor and *Meher* crop sales. Most of the country will remain in Minimal (IPC Phase 1) acute food insecurity from October 2018 to March 2019.

Following the October to January *Meher* harvest, food availability from own production will also increase but for a shorter period of time in East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones of Oromia, eastern parts of Amhara and Tigray regions as well as pockets of the Rift Valley and SNNPR. Livestock will also benefit from additional feed from crop residues and are expected to have enhanced body conditions, production and productivity between October and December, which will improve cash income access for households. Most of eastern Amhara and Tigray regions and pockets of the Rift Valley will be in Minimal (IPC Phase 1) from October to December as households have adequate food and income. On the other hand, lowland parts of East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones are Stressed (IPC Phase 2) currently. With the early exhaustion of stocks from the last *Belg* and *Meher* harvests food security is expected to deteriorate from Minimal (IPC Phase 1) between October and December to Stressed (IPC Phase 2) in eastern parts of Amhara and Tigray regions and from Stressed (IPC Phase 2) to Crisis (IPC phase 3) in East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones between January and May 2019.

In southern pastoral areas of Ethiopia between October 2018 and January 2019, Stressed (IPC Phase 2) and Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are expected to continue. *Hagaya/Deyr* rainfall will improve pasture and water availability, which will help to improve livestock production and productivity. However, although pastoral conditions continue to improve, households' livestock herd sizes still have not recovered from drought in 2016 and 2017, which continues to limit households' purchasing power. Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes are also expected throughout the scenario period in pastoral northern Afar, where successive mediocre to poor rainfall seasons have limited availability of pasture and water, in turn reducing livestock productivity and incomes from sales.

Areas of Oromia, SNNPR, Somali, and Benishangul Gumuz that have seen significant ethnic clashes in 2018 are also expected to continue to face Crisis (IPC Phase 3) outcomes throughout the scenario period. Displaced households and worst-affected resident populations directly impacted by the insecurity have limited livelihood opportunities and are expected to remain highly reliant on humanitarian assistance provision. Humanitarian actors are reaching some of these populations, including

WFP in the Somali region, with the provision of emergency food assistance.

AREAS OF CONCERN

Harshin-Degahbur East Pastoral Livelihood Zone (HDP), Jarar zone, Somali region (Figure 3)

Current Situation

Harshin-Degahbur Pastoral (HDP) livelihood zone experienced three successive below average rainy seasons (*Deyr* 2016, *Gu* 2017, and *Deyr* 2017). In these seasons, major parts of the livelihood zone had seasonal total rainfall that was less than 55 percent of the long-term average. However, although it was below average, the rainfall situation during the 2017 *Deyr* was

better than previous seasons in the eastern part of the livelihood zone and it improved the pasture and water situation. This supported somewhat the improvement of livestock body conditions of large and small ruminants alike.

The onset of the 2018 *Gu* in the livelihood zone was timely and cumulative performance was above average even though the end of the rains came earlier than normal. The current water and pasture availability is sufficient to sustain livestock feed needs for the zone throughout the current October to December *Deyr* season.

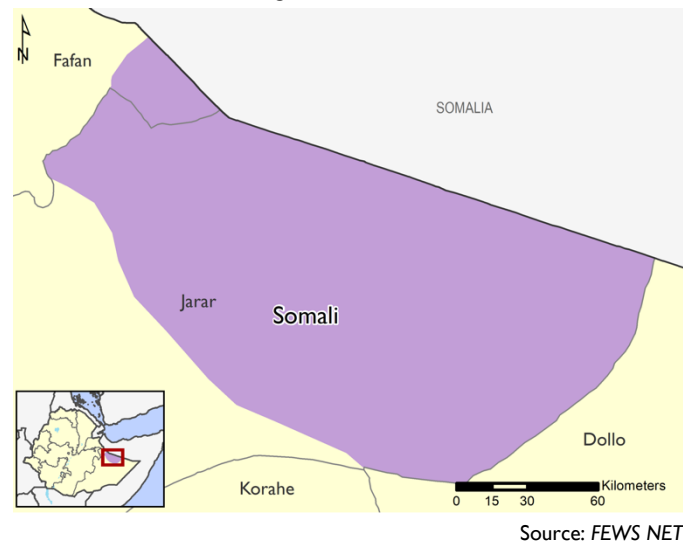
Livestock body conditions and productivity have continued to improve in the zone since late 2017/early 2018, owing to the relatively good rainfall performance and availability of pasture and water resources. Livestock birthing rates, however, are only recently starting to recover following the significant reduction in livestock herd sizes in late 2016 and 2017. Households also need to, however, continue to maintain livestock sales to meet income requirements. Despite recent livestock births for both small and large ruminants, herd sizes still remain well below average, as noted during a recent FEWS NET assessment to the zone.

Imported foods (sugar, rice, and wheat flour) are the major food items consumed by households in the livelihoods zone. Political instability in the Somali region in August 2018 led to some decline in staple food trade flows and livestock prices. In September 2018, however, commodity and livestock prices started improving. Before August 2018, imported food trade in the region was monopolized by small elite businesses. After August 2018, boarder trade opened up further. This increased supply competition, benefiting from formal disruptions during the political instability in August, improved supply and has at least in the short-term improved purchase prices for imported staples. In Degehabur, the market price of rice and sugar in September 2018 was 18 and 8 percent lower, respectively, compared to July 2018. However, prices are still higher than last year (+7 percent for sugar) and the five-year average (+30 percent for sugar).

Livestock prices exhibited a slight decline in September 2018, after peaking in July 2018, which marked the end of the Haji season. Sheep and goat prices in September 2018 were 15 percent lower than in July 2018. Nevertheless, owing to improved livestock body conditions, current prices are still higher than last year at the same time (+22 percent) and the five-year average (+26 percent).

The prevalence of acute malnutrition in rural areas is expected to be currently lower than the same time last year due to increased access to milk and other foods. Save the Children International monitoring of SAM admissions in their stabilization center between January and July 2018 in Jarar zone shows an increasing trend from March to June 2018, which then started to decline in July 2018. However, as the reporting rate in July 2018 was 50%, it difficult to make a definitive conclusion. While the trend in admissions was increasing last summer, it appears to have been decreasing in summer 2018.

Figure 3. Reference map, Harshin-Degahbur East Pastoral Livelihood Zone, Somali region



The livelihood zone is supported by both emergency and PSNP food assistance programs. In HDP livelihood zone there are 91,878 emergency beneficiaries and 78,022 PSNP beneficiaries. The 2018 PSNP transfer program was completed in June 2018. Assistance for direct support was not done from July through September 2018. Beneficiaries in the emergency food assistance program are reportedly receiving a relief basket of 15 kg sorghum, 1.5 kg pulses and 0.45 kg oil per person once every two and a half months.

Assumptions

In addition to the national-level assumptions described above, the following area-level assumptions have been used to develop the most-likely scenario for Harshin-Degahbur Pastoral Livelihood Zone for October 2018 to May 2019:

- Sheep and goats that conceived in the 2018 *Gu* and Camels that conceived in the 2017 *Deyr* that have not yet birthed will do so in November 2018, which will intern improve, relative to the last year, milk availability.
- Pasture and water availability is expected to seasonally improve during the *Deyr*, which in turn will lead to improved livestock body conditions and productivity. However, due to the high level of livestock deaths and sales in 2016/17, cumulative livestock sale and productivity, including milk, will remain below average. During the scenario period, the supply of livestock on markets will remain limited as pastoralists continue to restock their herds. With the low market supply and good livestock body conditions, however, livestock sale prices per head are expected to remain favorable for pastoralists.
- The current insecurity between Oromia and Somali region is expected to continue to affect the supply of locally produced cereals from highland areas of Ethiopia.
- Humanitarian food assistance is expected to continue, although erratically, through December 2018. In 2019, humanitarian food assistance is not assumed to be planned, funded and likely.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

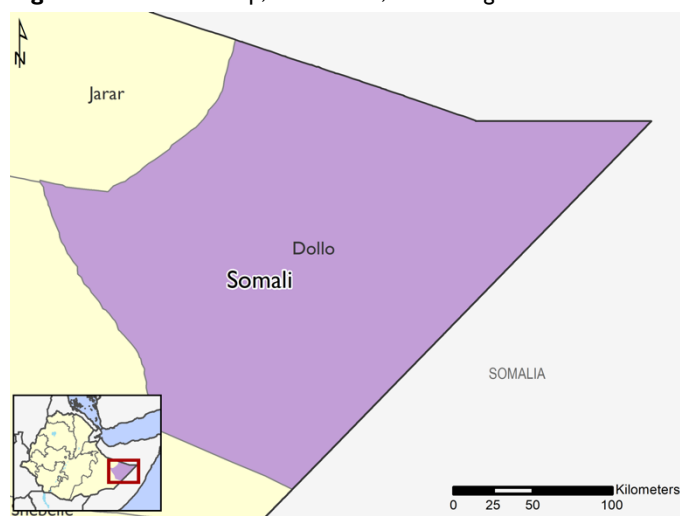
Although good rainfall during the 2018 *Gu* led to marked improvements in pastoral conditions and livestock body conditions and productivity, the lingering impacts of herd size losses due to drought in 2016 and 2017 continues to limit households' access to food and income. Although the rate of livestock births is rebounding, herd productivity is not expected to begin to return to more normal levels until mid-2019.

The improved livestock body conditions and reduce supply of livestock for sale on markets has led to increased livestock sale prices, however. Purchase prices for staple foods have trended down in recent months, but prices still remain higher than last year and the five-year average. Poor households in particular still have few saleable animals to meet income needs for purchase and will continue to face significant difficulty meeting basic food needs through the first half of 2019 as they restock their herds. Moreover, a high number of poor households remain displaced in IDP camps. The zone is expected to remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) throughout the October 2018 to May 2019 scenario period.

Dollo zone, Somali region (Figure 4)

Dollo zone faced severe droughts in 2016 and 2017 that very significantly restricted pasture and water resource availability and contributed to substantial livestock deaths and excess sales. Recent assessments show, however, that successful rainy season in late 2017 and in 2018 have contributed to significant improvements in the availability of pasture and water. As a result, livestock production, herd sizes and milk availability have also improved. Food access among pastoralists in many areas

Figure 4. Reference map, Dollo zone, Somali region



also improved in the first half of 2018 due to better livestock-to-cereal terms of trade, although the availability of saleable animals remains limited.

As per the 2018 *Gu* assessment findings of the regional DPPC, despite all improvements, there are pressing humanitarian needs in Dollo zone due to the high reduction in livestock herd sizes, total herd productivity, and the availability of saleable livestock in the herd. This was also confirmed by the May 2018 food security and nutrition survey conducted by FEWS NET. The survey shows the nutritional status, of the IDPs in particular, in Dollo zone was remained elevated in the presence of aggravating factors such as lack of safe drinking water for human and very poor sanitation practices in the community, high disease prevalence, and low measles and vitamin A supplementation coverage. The survey also revealed that severe food security outcomes were still likely present among some worst-affected households at the end of the *Gu* season.

Although the start of seasonal rainfall in October was well below-average, forecasts indicate total seasonal October to December 2018 *Deyr* rainfall is likely to be average to slightly below average and will contribute to continued improvements in livestock productivity and livestock holdings. Breeding camels conceived in the 2017 *Deyr* and sheep and goats conceived during the 2018 *Gu* are expected to birth between October and December 2018. This will improve access to milk, however the overall volume of the milk produced is expected to be lower than normal years due to the small herd sizes. Favorable market conditions for both imported items and livestock, are expected to contribute to further improvements in the overall food security condition between now and May 2018. However, acute food insecurity is prevalent among populations who lost most of their animals and who became displaced during the 2016 and 2017 droughts. The availability of saleable animals will remain low throughout the scenario period, and for many households some of the income from their livestock sales will have to go toward debt repayment. Thus, significant populations in the zone will continue to face significant difficulty meeting basic food needs as Dollo zone remains in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between October 2018 and May 2019.

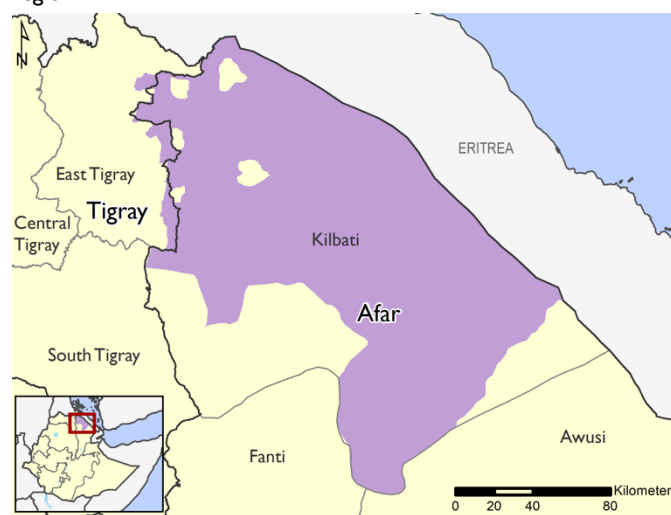
Asale Pastoral Livelihood Zone (ASP), Afar region (Figure 5)

Current Situation

After experiencing widespread below-normal March to May *Sugum* rainfall June to September 2018 Karan/Karma 2018 rains produced mixed performance. Rains started on time and progressed with an average to above average amount and distribution throughout the season in central and southwestern Afar. However, in north and northeastern parts of Afar and Sitti zone of Somali region, seasonal start of rainfall was delayed by two weeks and cumulative rains were below average and erratic in distribution. Northern Afar rainfall was 15 to 30 percent below average in this zone that already receives on marginal amounts of rainfall even in a normal year. Remote sensing observations for rainfall were confirmed by FEWS NET field assessments in Berehale, Abala, and Koneba where key informants indicated the total number of rainy days did not exceed 7 to 10 days. However, areas where seasonal rains were below normal bordering Amhara and Tigray were able to benefit from flood waters from the highlands.

Successive below-average rainy seasons led to only marginal availability of pasture and water for livestock since September that is only expected to last for a couple of months. In areas where moisture deficits are worst, which includes Ayelibahi, Ayeturaha, Argale, and Nema Gudi in Afdera woredas, pasture/browse and water scarcity is more prevalent, and its effects are already seen in livestock body conditions. The poor availability of pasture and water forced atypical levels of camel abortions and limited the number of sheep/goat births. FEWS NET's qualitative assessment from an August 2018 field visit is that herd sizes and the number of milking animals were down between 10 and 25 across much of the zone.

Figure 5. Reference map, Asale Pastoral Livelihood Zone, Afar region



Source: FEWS NET

The supply of staple foods on markets is somewhat restricted, which has contributed to the price of staple cereals remaining high. As per data from the Regional DRMC, the maize price in Abala (north Afar) market in September 2018 is 33 percent higher than last year at the same time and 26 percent above the four-year average. In Abala market in September 2018 goat prices were, however, 30 percent higher than last month and last year and 86 percent above the four-year average. This has contributed to livestock-to-cereal terms of trade remaining rather stable, but households have fewer saleable animals.

According to TFP admission data, admissions for malnutrition treatment between January and July 2018 in Afedera, Berhale, Bidu, and Magale woredas increased by 37, 33, 68, 67 and 85 percent respectively compared to 2017. TFP admission numbers were lower for January to June 2018 in Abala and Kuneba woredas, areas that benefited from geographic proximity to the highlands of Tigray where runoff improved pasture conditions. In September 2018, Plan International and GOAL Ethiopia reported a total of 411 SAM cases identified in Afar for OTP and stabilization center treatment and out of which 34 of them were with medical complication.

Assumptions

In addition to the national-level assumptions described above, the following area-level assumptions have been used to develop the most-likely scenario for Asale Pastoral Livelihood zone for October 2018 through May 2019:

- From October 2018 to February 2019, availability of local livestock feed and water is expected to continue to decline significantly during the *Jillal* season. Pastoralists are expected to migrate their livestock neighboring Tigray and Amhara regions (typical migration locations) in search of fodder and water. The long distances traveled will contribute to a reduction of livestock body conditions and livestock production.
- Households are expected to engage in livestock sales that further reduce their herd sizes in an attempt to meet food consumption needs. In addition, households will engage in some self-employment activities such as salt mining.
- Staple food prices are expected to decline seasonably from November 2018 to January 2019 due the availability of *Meher* harvests. Staple food prices will seasonally increase again from February to May 2019.
- Cash and in-kind assistance, including camel milk gifts, that normally poor and very poor households receive from better-off households is expected to decrease significantly during the October 2018 to February 2019 dry *Jillal* season due to limited livestock productivity.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Many poor household livestock herds were still recovering from the 2015 El Niño drought. Below-average rainfall in 2018 again contributed to reducing herd sizes and will also lead to poor livestock body conditions and productivity throughout the 2018/19 *Jillal* dry season. Although the seasonal decline in staple food prices, good sale prices for saleable livestock, and incomes from remittance and salt mining will have positive contributions to food access, overall incomes will not be sufficient to cover household needs. The expected good performance of rains in early 2019 is likely to bring an improvement in pasture and water availability and increase small livestock conceptions. However, greater food access resulting from these improvements is not expected until after the March to May *Sugum* rains, and the zone is expected to remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) from October 2018 through May 2019.

East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones, Oromia region (Figure 6)

Current Situation

June to September 2018 *Kiremt* rainfall started late by more than two weeks and was erratic and uneven in distribution, particularly in lowland areas. Although rainfall improved starting around mid-August, it ceased the first week of September 2018. Total seasonal cumulative rainfall was below average. Areas worst-affected by moisture stress include Boke, Guba Koricha, Hawi Gudina, Gimbi Bordede, and Anchare woredas of West Hararghe and Fedis, Medhaga Tolla, Kurfa Chele, Gursum, Chinakson, and Babile woredas of East Hararghe. Because of the poor rainfall performance, harvest prospects in lowland areas are not good. Agricultural activities in highland and some midland areas of the two zones were relatively better than lowland parts and currently crops, particularly long cycle varieties, are near the harvesting stage. *Meher* cropping was also significantly affected in some kebeles of East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones due to intercommunal conflicts with Somali region. Unrest that has also led to displacement continues in some kebeles of Chinakson, Babile, Midaga Tolla, and Gursum woredas of East Hararghe and Doba and Meiso woredas of West Hararghe. The unrest is at times also inhibiting access at times for emergency food distribution by operators.

Figure 6. Reference map, East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones, Oromia region



Source: FEWS NET

Rainfall in 2018 was, however, largely sufficient for pasture and watering point regeneration for livestock. Additionally, crop residues from failed plantings were able to be used for animal feed. The overall physical condition of livestock is mediocre to normal in most all areas of these zones.

Rainfall in 2018 was, however, largely sufficient for pasture and watering point regeneration for livestock. Additionally, crop residues from failed plantings were able to be used for animal feed. The overall physical condition of livestock is mediocre to normal in most all areas of these zones.

Generally, cereal market supply is relatively stable, but prices remain high compared to average. However, livestock prices are significantly higher compared to the same month last year. The price of an average-sized goat in Anchare market in September was 60 percent higher than the same time last year.

From January to July 2018, a total of 78,111 SAM cases were treated in Oromia region with an average of 86 % reporting rate. The January to July 2018 TFP admissions are 11.2 and 9.2 percent higher compared to the total TFP admission for the same period last year and the six-year average (2011-2016), respectively. Similarly, July 2018 TFP admissions were 11.3, 34.8 and 28.3 percent higher compared to the previous month, same month of last year and the same month in 2016, respectively.

Various factors are likely driving an increase in malnutrition in these two zones. They include inadequate food availability at the household level, aggravated by limited market access, health and nutrition services interruption, household displacement and instability due to conflict, inadequate potable water supply, as well as irregularity or delay of general food distributions and TSFP nutrition intervention. According to Oromia ENCU's October 5th report, between August 25 and 30 September 2018, a total of 59 AWD cases were treated from Gimbi Bordode and Anchare woredas of West Hararghe zone. Similarly, there were AWD cases reported in September 2018 in Haromaya woreda of East Hararghe.

According to the zonal DPPDs, the conflict between Oromo and Somali ethnic groups resulted in a significant displacement of people. More than 98,758 new IDPs were recorded in East Hararghe zone between July 28 and August 16, 2018. 193,467 IDPs are hosted in Chinakson, Babile and Gursum woredas of the zone. Moreover, according to the West Hararghe DPPD, more than 129,634 IDPs are hosted in the zone. In general, conflict has disrupted households' livelihood activities, including agriculture, and livestock keeping, and petty trading.

Emergency relief food assistance is ongoing for 641,077 and 711,225 beneficiaries in East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones, respectively, including response to conflict-affected IDPs. As of October 2018, the 4th round of food aid is dispatched, and the distribution was started in both zones by JEOP and NDRMC. However, food distributions can be irregular.

Assumptions

In addition to the national-level assumptions described above, the following area-level assumptions have been used to develop the most-likely scenario for East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones for October 2018 through May 2019:

- According to the NOAA NMME rainfall forecast for October – December 2018, some unseasonal rains are likely to occur over seasonally dry regions of East Hararghe and West Hararghe zones.
- Below-average harvest production is anticipated from the current *Meher* harvests. The current water sources and pasture are expected to exhaust earlier than normal. However, regeneration of pasture and water is expected to be near normal following the expectedly near-average *Belg* 2019 rainfall.
- Livestock production and productivity is expected to be average during the first part of the scenario period (October 2018 to January 2019). However, it is likely to decline the beginning of February 2019 as current water sources and pasture are exhausted earlier than normal. There is a risk, however, for livestock disease outbreaks given the recent black leg outbreak in summer 2018.
- Livestock prices are expected to remain stable or improve slightly between November 2018 and January 2019, before gradually decreasing between February and May 2019.
- Prices of locally produced staple foods, such as maize and sorghum, are expected to show seasonal declines from December onwards and will remain above average on most markets through May 2019.
- Conflict between Oromo and Somali groups is expected to persist throughout the scenario period.

Most Likely Food Security Outcomes

Because of late *Meher* season planting, green and main harvests are not expected to substantially begin before November. Consequently, cereal supplies on local markets are expected to arrive somewhat late but will still contribute to improved supply in the short term, instigating a seasonal decline in staple food prices through February 2019. Incomes from livestock sales are expected to remain good. Moreover, the forecasted unseasonal rainfall in October and November will improve chat cultivation, the sale of which is an important source of income in these zones. Consequently, household food access from purchase and own production is expected to slightly improve between October 2018 and January 2019 in midland and highland areas. However, households worst-affected by consecutive poor seasons in lowland areas, and conflict affected IDPs and resident households will continue to face restricted food access due to limited harvest stocks and access to markets and will remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) through January 2019.

Food access from own production stocks is likely to exhaust earlier than usual even in midland and highland areas and market access will become more difficult due to seasonal price increases after January. Livestock incomes will help to maintain some market access, but poor households in lowland areas in particular will face significant difficulty meeting their basic food needs. As such, lowland areas of the zones are expected to remain in Crisis (IPC Phase 3) between February and May 2019.

EVENTS THAT MIGHT CHANGE THE OUTLOOK

Table I. Possible events over the next eight months that could change the most-likely scenario.

Area	Event	Impact on food security outcomes
National	New conflict events in areas not already facing intercommunal violence	Restricted access to livelihood activities and household displacement would lead to restricted food access.
Southern pastoral areas	Below-average October to December 2018 <i>Deyr/Hageya</i> rains	Poor regeneration of pasture and water resources that would negatively impacted livestock productivity, limit herd size regeneration, and negatively impact household incomes as livestock body conditions atypically deteriorated. This would affect food access for poor and very poor households in the short-term.
National	Planned, funded, and likely humanitarian assistance throughout the scenario period	The continuation of humanitarian food assistance, that was not considered in the above scenarios as it is not yet planned, funded, and likely, would contribute to increasing food access.
Pastoral areas	Atypical livestock disease outbreaks	Livestock disease outbreaks would directly affect pastoral and agropastoral communities, reducing livestock productivity and restricting incomes from sales.

ABOUT SCENARIO DEVELOPMENT

To project food security outcomes, FEWS NET develops a set of assumptions about likely events, their effects, and the probable responses of various actors. FEWS NET analyzes these assumptions in the context of current conditions and local livelihoods to arrive at a most likely scenario for the coming eight months. [Learn more here.](#)